

THE
NORTHWEST COAST;

OR,

THREE YEARS' RESIDENCE IN WASHINGTON
TERRITORY.

BY JAMES G. SWAN.



WITH NUMEROUS ILLUSTRATIONS.

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a principal item in the stock of provisions the Indians lay by for their winter use.

The rivers and mountain streams abound in trout. Flatfish, such as turbot, soles, and flounders, are plenty, and in the spring, innumerable shoals of herring visit the Bay, and are readily caught by the Indians, either with nets, or in weirs and traps, rudely constructed of twigs and brush.

The shores of the Bay, with the exception of the west or peninsular side, are mostly composed of high banks of a sandy clay, intermingled with strata of shells and remains of ancient forest-trees that for ages have been buried. The faces of these cliffs are generally perpendicular, particularly when washed by the waves of the Bay; but in some places they gradually descend to the water, having a level space, covered either with grass or bushes, close to the water's edge. The peninsula is a flat, marshy, and sandy plain, elevated but a few feet from the water level, and covered, as is also the whole region around the Bay, with a dense growth of gigantic forest-trees, principally spruce, fir, and cedar, with a few specimens of maple and ash, and black alder, which here grows to a tree.

There are three islands in Shoal-water Bay; one, at the North Bay, called Pine Island, is a small sand-islet of some four or five acres in extent, covered with low, stunted pine-trees and beach-grass. Some of the oystermen reside on it, as it is near the channel and the oyster-beds.

That portion of the Bay from its northern extremity to the southern point at the mouth of the River Palux (called Goose Point) is termed the North Bay, and all to the south of Goose Point, South Bay. About seventeen miles south of Goose Point is another island, called Long Island, some six or eight miles long, but narrow,

and not over a mile and a half wide at its greatest width. This island is covered with a thick forest, except in a few places, where there are small prairie patches, very rich, and easily cultivated. The timber, however, is of little account, and would scarcely pay the labor of clearing.

South of Long Island is another small islet, called Round Island, from its shape. It is small, not over two acres in extent, and covered with spruce-trees and bushes.

The various rivers running into the Bay are not of any great length. The Whil-a-pah, which is the longest, is navigable for vessels drawing from twelve to fifteen feet of water twenty miles from its mouth, and for boats to within a short distance of the Cowlitz River. The Palux and Nasal are only navigable for large vessels for a few miles from their mouths; but all the rivers, large and small, run through fine prairie-land, exceedingly rich. That portion nearest the Bay is liable to be overflowed once or twice during the highest tides of winter, and are termed tide lands. This overflowing is, however, of no detriment, although the water is salt, as, wherever the lands have been properly cultivated, they have yielded heavy crops.

These prairies are all covered with grass of an excellent quality, making good grazing for stock, or a nutritious fodder when cut and made into hay.

Elk, deer, and antelope are very plenty, and find ample sustenance at all seasons of the year. The other wild animals which abound are black bears, wolves, lynx, panthers, and in the streams are otter and beaver. There are also raccoons, foxes, rabbits, skunks and squirrels, minks, martens, and a singular species of rat, called the bush-tailed rat (*Neotoma Drummondii*). This animal is of a very mischievous nature, seeming to take delight in collecting all sorts of things, and conveying them to its